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Revised Standard Version

**Gen.1**

1 Before the trouble there was waking up in the void, unsure if he existed, unsure what it meant to exist. 2 There was no sense of past, of body, of thoughts, save that maybe it was Saturday. 3 The light slicing through the blinds changed that, led him towards memory. 4 He was Adam, and he was in his father's house. 5 He'd never known his mother, never seen so much as a photo. 6 Kids had teased him back in school, said he was stolen, or born to a jackal. 7 As he got older he found that no one had ever heard of his father with a woman, much less heard of a pregnancy, a birth, an infant. 8 When people asked him whathowwhywhenwho he had no answers. 9 He remembers spending hours in the cooler section of the market, checking photos on milk cartons, hoping to find himself.

10 That same day, the day the trouble began but still before it, there was Evelyn, too, lying next to him, asleep. 11 She'd appeared at his side on a day he broke his ribs and she'd never left. 12 In those early days they'd walked around the place nude, having enough sex to start the human race. 13 She was beautiful in the way an addict would understand. 14 She was like a '69 Mustang in a junkyard, dented, dusty and debilitated, her sensuality like a faded paint job needing only a coat of wax to be restored. 15 But she had a dark side, too, and there were nights down at the bar when she'd be tempted by some loser, leaning towards him as if she was about to fall.

16 The trouble came at Shrangi-la—their name for Costco—and no matter how insignificant the deed seemed at the time, it changed everything. 17 They'd been going to Shrangi-la for a long time without trouble, because they understood the rules. 18 They preferred to go on

Saturdays or Sundays because the place was absolute pandemonium. 19 They didn't have a membership and never went inside but anyway, the fun was outside. 20 On those days they'd get stoned and stand near the exit, watching with awe the endless procession of carts emerging from Shrangi-la, coveting the infinite variety of items sold, fantasizing about what they would buy ifwhen wealthy. 21 The whole thing was a great aphrodisiac and after a few hours they'd return home for sex fueled by lust and capitalism. 22 His father warned them there'd be hell to pay if they did anything stupid at Shangri-la. 23 There'd by hell to pay if they got into trouble over there.

**Gen.2** (see Gen.1, with variations)

**Gen.3**

1 Trouble came in the form of Old Nick, a beach-bum-looking-guy Evelyn met at the bar. 2 He had an easy smile, and Adam made Evelyn promise to stay away from him. 3 Adam warned her that he spoke with a forked tongue, but Old Nick was slimy, buying her drinks and whispering things that made her laugh. 4 One night Evelyn told Old Nick about the trips to Shrangi-la and on that day, the day of trouble, he showed up. 5 Adam didn't like the intrusion, thought this was a gig for two. 6 Old Nick ignored Adam, focusing all his intention on Evelyn. 7 He tantalized her, suggesting it would be a simple thing to grab something from one of the carts when the shoppers looked away.

8 "I don't know," Evelyn said.

9 "It's all in how you do it," Old Nick said. 10 "You grab one thing they won't even notice, not with all that shit they got. 11 What can they do, anyway? 12 Kill you?"

13 “Why don’t *you* do it then?” Adam asked.

14 Old Nick shrugged and went over to stand near the door. 15 When a woman spent a few extra seconds talking to a door checker, Old Nick snaked his arm down into the cart and snagged an apple. 16 He took a big bite as he walked towards them, smiling like the bastard he was. 17 Still, Adam couldn’t deny this was more fun than they typically had.

18 “No big thing,” Old Nick said. 19 “Try it. 20 You won’t die or anything.”

21 Evelyn looked at Adam, her eyes wide at the idea, at the thrill of it. 22 She came so close her breath was warm against his ear. 23 “Think how hot *that* will make me,” she said.

24 “We don’t need the trouble,” Adam said.

25 A fat couple pushing a cart with a tower of goods reaching into the heavens came out. 26 The checker at the door called after them and they both turned back.

27 “Do a dry run,” Old Nick said, his words fiery with anticipation. 28 “Just walk over to their cart, you’ll see how easy it is. 29 Just a dry run,” Old Nick said.

30 Before Adam could say anything Evelyn walked over, reached into the cart and ran her hand over a package of steaks. 31 She walked back, smiling, some kind of evil set into her eyes now.

32 “That was *so* cool,” she said.

33 “Told you,” Old Nick said, grinning with delight.

34 “Evelyn,” Adam said.

35 But she was off again. 36 This time it was an old man pushing a not-so-loaded cart. 37 The man turned to argue with a woman, saying she was the cause of all of his problems, that before her everything was good. 38 Evelyn reached into the cart, pulled a bag of oranges out and hurried into the parking lot, towards their car. 39 Adam ran after her.

40 “What the hell did you do that for?” Adam asked.

41 “God!” she said, breathless. 42 “That turns me on. 43 Let’s go home and spike them with vodka and eat and fuck all day.”

**Gen.5**

1 Adam realized it wasn’t such a big thing, what Evelyn had done, in fact it was pretty cool, so he drove them home and they screwed for a hundred and thirty years.

**Gen.6**

1 His father came home and found them on the sofa, the two of them contorted like gymnasts doing a floor routine, Adam squeezing vodka-infused orange juice all over Evelyn’s body and slurping it up. 2 Orange peels and pulp were scattered throughout the house. 3 His father found the bag, saw the Costco sticker, and understood. 4 They pulled on their clothes. 5 “Why did you do that?” his father asked. 6 ”Because we were naked,” Adam said. 7 “Who told you that?” his father asked. 8 Adam and Evelyn sat on the sofa half-dressed, looking at each other, confused.

9 “I’m sorry I ever created a kid,” his father said. 10 Outside, it started to rain. 11 He got out his day planner and called the boat builder. 12 “You’re finished,” he said when he hung up, speaking in a wrathful tone Adam feared. 13 The rain came down harder, as if fire hoses had been unleashed in the heavens. 14 His father found another number and started dialing. 15 “You are so finished.”

16 “What are you going to do?” Adam asked. 17 Evelyn loudly sucked the juice from an orange as thunder rattled the panes. 18 “Come on,” Adam said. 19 Man, it was *really* raining outside. 20 “So we made a mistake. 21 Forgive us. 22 We won’t do it again.”

23 “You’re right about that,” his father said. 24 He pointed to the ceiling and raised his eyebrows. 25 “You hear that, smart guy? 26 You hear that rain?”

27 “But—“

**Gen.6**

1 His father held up a hand. 2 “Please. 3 Not now. 4 I have a flood to plan.”